

Indian sprint on the surge despite administrative flip-flops

A **stellar season** has propelled Animesh Kujur to the brink of India's first men's sprint appearance at the World Championships, even as tough schedules and unclear selection routines prove to be significant hurdles for sprinters at home.

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It has been a painfully sweet year for India's short-distance runners in 2025. Animesh Kujur, India's latest sprint headline act, is on the cusp of becoming the first Indian male sprinter to participate in the World Championships, to be held in Tokyo next month.

The 21-year-old has battled through a long, arduous season in which he ran 41 races in seven months across nine countries, breaking both the 100m and 200m National Records (NR) in the process.

The Odisha sprinter was also part of the 'dream team', which also included Manikanta Hoblidhar, Gurindervir Singh and Amlan Borgohain, that tore down the 4x100m relay NR set during the Delhi Commonwealth Games in 2010.

Gurindervir shattered the 100m NR with a 10.20s at the Indian Grand Prix in Bengaluru in March, only for Animesh to better it in Greece in July with 10.18s. The 200m crown at the National Inter-State Championships in Chennai is the latest accolade Animesh has added to his collection this year. Sitting down for a chat with *Sportstar* after the event, he shed light on the gruelling year he has endured.

"This was the last competition before the World Championships, and the coach wanted me to just get it done with. He asked me to get away from the track after the Continental Tour

Bronze event in Odisha. I warmed up for the first time in a week after arriving here," Animesh explained.

Manikanta had a similar tale. "I had no plan of participating in Inter-State. I had some pain in the adductor and missed the Continental Tour. I just did one session in Mumbai and flew here to participate," said the 24-year-old, who finished second in 100m. "The final didn't go to plan because I felt some tightness. God must have

Need for speed: Manikanta Hoblidhar (centre) won silver in 100m at the Inter-State Championships in Chennai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

